

## Learned ignorance



Aristotle's methodical, empiricist philosophy only gradually became integrated into Christianity in the late Middle Ages (see [Nominalism](#)). Part of the problem was that the Aristotelian approach, using the evidence of our senses and subjecting it to logical reasoning, was too down to earth and detracted from the mystical elements of religion. Realism, with its idea of another, perfect world of Universals, fitted better with Christian concepts such as the Trinity. In reaction to this almost scientific approach, some clung doggedly to Plato's ideas. Nicholas of Cusa (also known as Cusanus, or Nicolaus von Kues) went even further, proposing a 'learned ignorance'

reminiscent of Socrates. All our knowledge, he said, comes from what he called 'the One', or 'the Good', and God, who came before everything, necessarily came before that. It is therefore impossible to have any knowledge of God with the human mind. We can only use our reason to understand that we *cannot* know God, and through this 'learned ignorance' access the divine mind to comprehend God.